

0 (0s):

What is it about the bowling versus bowling alone that, that the data told you, and what were people reporting that you thought was important to, to get into?

1 (8s):

Well, first of all, bowling is big in America. You may not know this, but more Americans bowl than vote, For example. So, wow.

0 (15s):

So we gotta put, we gotta put polls at the bowling booth. When you put your fingers in, you should like get the little die, and then you vote straight up you Yeah. That's what we should be doing. Agreed. This is What Now with Trevor Noah, I cannot tell you how excited I'm to have you on the podcast. And I think, I think everyone will be, because Robert Putnam is one of those names that is surprisingly unknown, but then surprisingly, very well known, depending on who you ask.

0 (56s):

So If you ask a lot of people in the streets, If you said, do You Know Robert Putnam? They would probably maybe say no. Yes. But if the, the person on the street that you asked was somebody like Barack Obama. Yeah, yeah. Then he'd be like, yeah, I know Robert and I know him well. And you'd be like, wow.

1 (1m 9s):

No, actually, he would say, Bob, I've been over this. There's a really funny in New York Times interview in which the New York Times interview was trying to say, I know I'm, I'm New York Times reporter, pretty well connected. I know Robert Putnam. And Barack just says, no, it's Bob.

0 (1m 26s):

I like that. Hey, that's when you, that's when You Know somebody. So actually let's talk about that because it's Sure. Although it seems crazy, will tie into everything that we're gonna talk about today, loneliness community. And fundamentally, funny enough, how all of it is integral in making sure that a democracy actually works, which I think is very important in America right now, because people are wondering if this democracy can and will work, You Know, in the next few decades. Yeah. And we we're experiencing this around the world, but, but, but tell us a little bit about that. How does Barack Obama presence of the United States come to know you as Bob? How does this journey begin?

1 (2m 9s):

About 20 years ago, not, well, maybe not quite that 15 years ago maybe, I was trying to run a seminar. I was running a seminar of people, and the, the idea was to bring people from very, very diverse backgrounds together once every three months for a couple of years to try to figure out how to solve the problem of social isolation in America. And it's political consequences. It's not just loneliness. It's also affects, as you said, and we're kind of come back to that, the chances of democracy surviving. We had a big multidimensional matrix.

We wanted to make sure we had enough men and women and blacks and Asians and Latinos and whites and old and young and rich and poor, and business and labor, et cetera. You can imagine this multidimensional scheme.

1 (2m 51s):

Right. And we got into all filled, but we had one box that we had not yet filled for a young black community organizer. And my son, who had been at Harvard Law School said, You Know, you ought to check out this really bright guy I know who I play basketball with, because it turns out my, my son, this is gonna make you believe in the conspiracy theory of American life. My son happened to be on the Harvard Law Review with Barack, and they played basketball together. Wow. And he said, well, he's a, he's a community organizer out in Chicago. I said, bingo, that sort of fits our, You Know, the right matrix. Right. So we got this guy here, he's one of the youngest people in the group.

1 (3m 33s):

And and he's very ambitious. It's clearly, he is very ambitious, but he is also cute. He's a little bit like the mos like

0 (3m 39s):

A,

1 (3m 40s):

Like a mascot in this group. And so, You Know, in like in a summer camp, people develop nicknames. And our nickname for him was the Governor. Because we thought, what a joke. This guy's ambitious and he thinks he's gonna eventually become hilarious governor of Illinois. This is the guy who five years later is the president of the United States.

0 (3m 59s):

So you weren't, you weren't wrong. Governor was a, a joke. He was a joke.

1 (4m 3s):

There was something else that's important about him. Yes. You Know, he's very smart, but he's also, at least he can be very quiet. So, and, and this is a group of, of Big Eagles. And so the first, You Know, we'd gather on a Friday night, Friday night, and all day, a must of Saturday up until lunch, everybody else was doing what we called station identification. That is, they were telling us how important they were and why their views were the most important. And, and Obama kept silent during all of that. And then after lunch he'd say, You Know, I've been listening to this. I I've been listening, especially to Susan and to Josh, and they think they disagree, but I think underneath Susan and Josh agree.

1 (4m 44s):

And they did. And everybody around the table was open mouth. How did he see that? We've been all sitting through the same conversation. And there was, the whole conversation was polarized in many different ways, but he saw a way in which he could frame an issue in ways that would be productive for the whole group going forward. Oh

0 (5m 3s):

Wow.

1 (5m 3s):

He's able to see through all this, You Know, all the fighting.

0 (5m 9s):

He's able to, he's able to connect groups that don't necessarily think they have anything that connects them. But I feel like that's the perfect jumping off point. Good. To get into your work, and I won't say single handedly 'cause you always give credit to your team, and I think that's important. But you have been at the forefront of helping us understand social isolation and why this can very well be the reason society, crumbles society as we know it. You Know, everyone talks about, we are more polarized than ever. People say like, oh, You Know, and I don't get along with the other parents at school. And people say like, I can't talk to my family because of politics and I, I don't even know my neighbor's names.

0 (5m 49s):

And, and, and at the same time, everyone says, I don't even know if this election will be the last one because democracy could be dead. Well, today we're gonna be speaking to the man who really has worked on helping us understand the data behind the feeling. And you've written a few books about this, You Know, bowling alone was obviously, I Mean, You Know, your, your seminal work, which was then it went on like an interesting journey. And we'll talk about some of it, You Know, the praise, the criticism. Right. And then you, you, you talked about like making democracies work, et cetera. But let's start with the fundamental problem at the bottom of it.

1 (6m 19s):

Sure.

0 (6m 20s):

Why Do you think it's such a big deal that people are, or say they're lonely? What is the value of minimizing social isolation?

1 (6m 30s):

Well, of course there are reasons to worry about people being lonely. That's indeed the title of this film that's now, You Know, out and about on Netflix and in theaters

0 (6m 41s):

That's Join or Die. Yeah.

1 (6m 42s):

Join or Die. Your chances of dying, well, your chances of dying are high. Actually, I've had before, sorry to say that, but your chances of dying over the next year are cut in half by joining one group. And that is their real serious health effects. And, and this is controlling for everything you like. It's, it's, it is really social isolation that causes premature death, but it also undermines the foundation for democracy. And that's another part of the title Join or Die, refers to the fact that, that Benjamin Franklin, at the time of the founding of the American Republic said, unless we join together, our democracy's gonna die. That it refers most of the personal effects which are big and to the collective effects.

1 (7m 25s):

And the collective effects, by the way, are not just democracy. Our, our economy grows more slowly, our society becomes more unequal. That political polarization is a big consequence of, of the lack of social capital and bowling alone. The book Bowling Alone first published in about 2000, but most of it was written in the late nineties, said, we've been going downhill for a long time in terms of our connections, all sorts of connections. We've been, we've been going to fewer club meetings, but we've been going on fewer picnics and we trust other people less, and we're less connected to our friends and, and to community organizations, but also to our family. All all those ways in which we connect, all of them turned out to be going down when I wrote that book.

1 (8m 11s):

And now 25 years later, it turns out they've gone down even further.

0 (8m 15s):

When you're talking about social connectedness, just, just to clarify this for people, what Do you mean? Because there are people who will say, but, but, but Robert, I, I've got followers on Instagram and I, I talk to people on my Facebook and I, You Know, I see people at school and What Do you mean? I I yeah,

3 (8m 30s):

Also off that I'm, I'm curious about the we, because my world is predominantly women and people of color, and our complaint is that we can't get rid of people. Like, You Know, like you've started off with like kind of this collective we, which I'd like to disrupt a bit, right? Sure. Because there is no real collective, we hence this kind of political, the political differences that we have. And black women in this country are probably one of the few groups where life expectancy is actually holding or going up. Right. And one of the reason they say that, and one of the reasons black women vote the way they do and behave the way they do, is because they have this deep sense of community among each other. So I'd say speaking for black women,

statistically these aren't black women's problems.

3 (9m 11s):

And that's often 'cause we are the carers, we are the people that are looking after children, elderly family members, they're looking to us. So I, I don't know many isolated black women in the way that you speak of. Also, I say just like ethnically, I'm Nigerian, British, I'm ibo. It wasn't just about my tribe, it was about my clan, which is the aha people. And we had this group where people pay dues all the time. And when my great uncle died, part of the Jews contributed to his funeral. So I think for ethnic minorities in this country, whether it's Latinos, it's African Americans, it's Asians, there are different cultural ties there that the idea of when I read, pick up the newspaper and I hear a story of somebody dying alone and they don't find the body for months.

3 (9m 54s):

I'm like, how does that happen? Because there's 20 people knocking your door within. But, but you see, it's, and I'm, I'm not saying that from my personal experience.

0 (9m 59s):

No, no. But You Know, no, I'm, so, I will say, funny enough, I hear you both saying the same thing genuinely. So, You Know, if, if I listen to what you're saying, Robert, you're saying that our life expectancy is directly tied to how many groups we are a part of, right? And how close those are. Yeah. And how close those are. And everything I'm hearing you say funny enough is, and I understand the delineation of like the, we, but I Mean we use the we in many different ways, but I hear you saying the same thing. You're going, black women's life expectancy is holding and going up in America because partly they are in these tight-knit groups. And so maybe that's sort of what I would like us to figure out is what are some groups holding onto that other groups are letting go of?

0 (10m 43s):

'cause I, I agree with you. I think even If I look at my life, You Know, Robert, I grew up in South Africa. I know

1 (10m 48s):

Your, your life. I read your life story,

0 (10m 50s):

So damn I know your life and Christiana grew up in, in London. Right. But Right. We have similarities. And, and the main thing for me was, till this day, even black women almost never found themselves without a community. And they worked towards it. So my grandmother was part of a thing called a society where all the grandmothers would come together and they would put their money into a collection, and one member would get money every single month. And then there was like a funeral society as well. And that was just a group of people who come together to talk about funerals. And then there was another church society. And

that it's self-explanatory. And so maybe that's what I wanna try to get to.

0 (11m 32s):

'cause I actually hear you both saying the same thing. And correct me if I'm wrong, I think the we you're talking about is like all of us, every single human being in a society. And Christiana what you're saying is like, You Know, black women don't seem to have the same issue. So maybe let's dig into that. You did a lot of this work in Italy, right? A lot of your seminal work came from Italy originally. Yes, yes. And, and a lot of the time, You Know, when I'm having conversations about what happens in America, I'll say to people, I know America is the be all and end all for many people, but I think a lot of America's issues and ideas can be solved or have been solved in other countries. You Know, you go to Italy and really you, you're on this journey of trying to understand why democracies work better or worse, or even to get more granular, you're trying to understand why some people trust government more, why some people trust institutions more and why some governments and institutions are working better for the people that they're looking after.

0 (12m 33s):

Right. And help me understand how Italy ties the story together for you. What Do you learn in Italy?

1 (12m 40s):

Well, I wanna step back just a little bit. If you were a botanist and wanted to study plant growth, how a plant was influenced by its environment, you'd take genetically identical seeds, you'd plant them in different pots of soil, you'd water them differently. And then you'd measure and see how, You Know which plants flourished and which faltered. And then you knew it'd be something that you did in the soil or something, or how much you watered them. That's what Italians did in Italy. In 1970, they created a new set of regional governments all across Italy from the up in the Alps to down in Sicily. Hmm. They all had the same powers and money, they looked the same on paper, but the environments into which they were implant in were very, very different.

1 (13m 26s):

Some were very advanced economically, some were very backward economically, some were Catholic, some were communists, et cetera. And so we over, for 20, 25 years, followed those regional governments. We could see that some of them were very successful, not only in terms of were they able to build daycare centers when they planned to, but also in terms of what did the people think. And so we could see there were some successful governments and some failures. And then the question is, well, what was in the soil? And we had a lot of different ideas. We thought maybe it was just economic wealth made the difference, or we thought maybe it was education that made a difference, but we didn't guess what it turned out to be, which was choral societies, singing groups, and football clubs and so on.

1 (14m 7s):

By which, I Mean some, in some places of Italy, people in the region connected with one another across

various lines singing together. So that's what we came to call social capital. We were talking about these bonds that brought people in a given region or community together across lines. And in northern Italy, especially north central Italy, around bologna, For example, there was a lot of, a lot of that kind of what I came to call social capital. That is these connections among people. And they had very effective, still do very, very effective regional governments. But some places, especially in the south, they didn't, they didn't have those kinds of groups and they didn't, and they had terrible, corrupt, inefficient, never answered the phone.

1 (14m 57s):

Even regional governments. Now, what I want to, and now I'm coming back to what Christiana asked about. Did they just have no groups down there? No, they had very tiny little groups, families. They, they looked after their own immediate family, but weren't involved in groups with people, You Know, even on the other side of the street, much less on the other side of town. Now, what I'm trying to say is there, we was strong, but very narrow. And what was characteristic up north was that they had much broader groups in which people from different families and different walks of life would come together to sing.

1 (15m 40s):

Now Christiana, I may not have persuaded you in what I've said now, but I've tried to convey the way I hear your objections. I think

3 (15m 49s):

No, I, but I, I actually come from that world, a huge extended family, a huge church family. My husband's an only child, but comes from a big extended family and loads of friends. So my conception of, as much as I had the depth of my clan and my ethnic group, You Know, when I, it was time to dedicate my kids, I flew back to London. So it happened in the home church, what I was dedicated in. Sure. A man that christened me, christened my children. Right. Do You Know what I Mean? So like, this is, I I, I guess what I'm trying to articulate is that for a lot of people, maybe from similar backgrounds as mine, that's a conceit already that like, the fact that this, it's not foreign. Do you, do you get where I'm going from?

0 (16m 26s):

Yeah, yeah, I hear

3 (16m 26s):

What you're saying. Yeah. So like, it's like I, but it's like this extended group and clan and so it's very different and it's very diverse.

0 (16m 33s):

So there's, there's one thing I want I want us to get to in a way, maybe let's start with, with this part. The why, why, why does it change anything? So what I love about this story is, You Know, oftentimes when we, when

we're talking about an issue in society, as you say, because we don't have all of the data, and because we, we have confirmation bias, we'll pick the thing that we, we think is the cause, right? And we'll stick with it. So we go, oh, society's declining because of social media. Oh, society's declining because of politics. Oh, society's declining because, okay, but you had a natural experiment that very few, You Know, social scientists will ever have help.

0 (17m 15s):

Help us understand the why in that. I, I would love to know why your government will work better if your community has more clubs in it. I, I don't think that's, that correlation is, is easy for everyone to see.

1 (17m 26s):

Let me see if I can explain it this way. If you see people regularly, and you're good friends, I don't mean intimate friends, but You Know, you, you have a good, good friendship. Yeah. Much less a, a deeper friendship. What tends to evolve is a norm of reciprocity that is, I'll do this for you now without expecting something back immediately from you, because down the road we'll see each other at choir practice and you'll do something for me. I'll do this for you now without expecting something back. And indeed, if everybody in the community is connected, I'll do something for somebody who I don't actually know. Because if other people watching see that I'm cheating him, they won't play games with me.

1 (18m 9s):

So in other words, everybody learns that the people in this town are go, are nice to each other. Wouldn't wouldn't you love live in a place where people were nice to each other? Yeah. Yeah, yeah, yeah. And moreover, and this is the main point of bowling alone, we learned when we carried those ideas back to the United States, that that has changed over time. There have been periods in American history when we did have connections with other people. I grew up in a small town in Ohio in the nine, late 1950s, and nobody locked their door. And when I told my children and grandchildren that they said they think grandpa's lying, but no, in that period, and it wasn't about race. There were, there were black kids.

1 (18m 51s):

I played football. I, there's a picture on the cover of bowling alone of me in my bowling league when I was in the, in junior high school, and there are three white guys. I'm the tall, skinny, one in the middle, and there are two black eyes. And so this was not about race. I mean, it didn't, it wasn't bounded. This trust and reciprocity was not bounded then there by race. I'm not saying race was not a problem, of course it was. But I mean, in terms of this, in a small town in the 1950s, right?

0 (19m 19s):

Right, right. People

1 (19m 20s):



Left their door unlocked. And that's because of what I had my jargon call social capital. So all I'm saying is not that every single person in America has lost trust or has become untrustworthy, but on average, and we've now shown this to be true all over America, people are less connected and therefore less trustworthy than they used to be. There are differences across America, and the places that are still relatively high are in social connection, are somewhat more trustworthy and feed they, I'm sorry, I'm gonna tell you more social science than you wanna know.

1 (20m 0s):

People do an interesting study. They drop letters on the street with money in them sealed, but with money in them and addressed. And then they ask of, in any given town or in neighborhood, how many of those letters are actually put in the mailbox so the owner can get their money back

0 (20m 18s):

Enough. What a fascinating experiment.

1 (20m 20s):

There are cities in America where your odds of getting your money back, if you're dropping in an envelope, dropping on the street are zero. And there are places, this is hard to believe. There are places in America where If you drop an envelope with money in it, the you're 80% likely to get the money back. So that's amazing differences. Yeah.

0 (20m 38s):

So Bob, maybe, maybe help us understand, You Know, the, the idea of bowling alone. Sure. Because I, I think, You Know, it is important to help people understand that first of all, it is an example. Yes. Right? And, and, and I think what you liked about it is sort of why it connects with me is that it's a simple example to understand, right? Yeah. Because everyone can go bowling, but it's the alone that really became the signifier that showed what was going wrong in America. And in many other parts of the world where people are experiencing this. So help, help us understand,

1 (21m 7s):

There's been virtually no decline in bowling itself, but it used to be that people bowled in teams in leagues, and the, there has been a complete collapse of team bowling, of League bowling. And when I told a friend of mine that he said, oh, you mean we're bowling alone? And I thought, that's a good title for a book. If ever I write a book about this. And it turned out to be a good title. But what, what is the difference? What is the experiential difference?

0 (21m 36s):

Yes.

1 (21m 37s):

Christiana, have you ever bowled?

3 (21m 40s):

Yeah, a couple times, but I'm from England, so Yeah, that's true. More of a, so more of a football, football team culture? No,

1 (21m 46s):

No. Like, okay, I just wonder. So actually I know where every bowling alley in London is, because whenever I've gone over there, I'm selling, selling books.

0 (21m 57s):

Every,

1 (21m 58s):

Every journalist thought their clever idea would be to interview me in a bowling alley so I can have fun thank you to every bowling alley in Central London. That's funny. In a, in bowling, in a bowling in a league, there are five people on a team and two teams are playing against each other. And how well you do depends on how well the team does not how well you individually do. And at any given time, two people are up at the lane throwing the ball down, but the other eight people are sitting in a semicircle at the back of the alleys and they're mostly talking, You Know, and they're talking about what was on TV last night, or they're talking, but occasionally they're talking about, You Know, the local schools or, or You Know, whether there should, a bond issue should be passed to cover the costs of the new sewer system or whatever.

1 (22m 45s):

And now I'm gonna suddenly change that description. Occasionally they're con they're having a conversation about public civic life that's highfalutin for saying they just had got into a discussion with people they know. Well, remember, they, these are people they see every week and they know how to interpret what the people say. They're not total strangers because they, because they fall in a league and with other members of the team. And, but they're also real human beings. And so the reason I decided to use that as a metaphor is it does say, here are people who know each other. If you're in a team, they know each other and they're not doing politics, but occasionally it helps with the politics.

1 (23m 29s):

Does that make sense? I Mean, occasionally they're able to have a conversation that's a kind of responsible conversation. It's not just two guys yelling at each other or two gals yelling at each other. It's two people who are gonna have to get along because the next week they're gonna be back in the same bowling alley. Yeah. And it, so it seemed to me a useful way of describing how bowling in a league, in a team is not just fun. I mean, I, it is important to emphasize this. I really wish I'd done emphasize this more. Social capital can't just

be eat your spinach. It's gotta be fun too. I Mean, it's, it's, it's, it's so, and that's why I use the example of bowling league. It's not saying, oh, go to a, a good government meeting.

1 (24m 12s):

Well, who

0 (24m 12s):

Wants to go to

1 (24m 13s):

A good mother, good government meeting? It's gotta be fun. And bowling is fun. But it's also a little bit like a good government meeting is that I maybe exaggerating here, but that's, that's where the idea of bullying, of bullying together came. And then the opposite of that was we are just less opportunity for encountering people that we know well to talk occasionally about public affairs.

0 (24m 33s):

Right. If we only meet at a political rally, our conversations will only be political and then we'll forget what connects us. Yeah. One, one other thing I wanted to throw in, maybe here, I know your work is all about data, so I don't know If you have the data on this, but how much Do you think companies and jobs and capitalism and the way it's been employed in America over the past 50, 60 years has affected people's ability to do that? Because, You Know, when you're talking about let's go bowling together, I, I, I just think of personally friends of mine and how we always want to do things, but more often than not, people will say, ah, I would love to, but I work late that day.

0 (25m 15s):

Yeah, I wish I could, but I've gotta finish this thing for work. Yeah. Yeah. I want to. But I, You know, the, the work and the I and then it's like my kid and I gotta see the kid because I don't have childcare. Yeah. And I've got to, and I, and I wonder because you are a man who, as you say, you've lived through time, You Know, I, I would love to know if there's any data or any experience that you've had that has shown you that our ability to engage in a league with other people is directly affected by how much time our work gives us off to do that.

1 (25m 47s):

Remarkably, I've got good data on how people spend every hour of their day going back to the 1960s. Would you believe that's 60 year time trend? And, and it's very interesting. Invite me back for another two hours and I'll talk about how our, how our lives have changed. For example, back in the day in the sixties, we slept, the average American slept 7.5 hours a day. And that average is exactly 7.5 hours today. Wow. There's been no change on average. Some people speak more, some people say

0 (26m 21s):

No. That's impressive though. Still. Yeah.

1 (26m 22s):

But here's the complicated part. Actually, we're spending less time at work than we used to. Less time at work.

0 (26m 30s):

No ways.

1 (26m 30s):

So less time at work. So what do we do without extra time? All of it is spent in front of screens. There's been a steady, steady long-term rise in the amount of time we spend in front of screens. And the most recent data, you might think, well, okay, it used to be screens like television and now it's screens like, You Know.

0 (26m 52s):

Yeah, yeah.

1 (26m 53s):

Some, You Know, some social

0 (26m 54s):

Media phones and iPads and whatever. Yeah,

1 (26m 55s):

Yeah, yeah. No, but it isn't, we're actually spending more time watching TV than we used to. And we're adding to that. I've now, don't quote me exactly. 'cause I Mean, I've got the data, I just don't have it in front of me at this moment. I didn't know you were gonna ask me this question. We are added, we've added since the advent of, of social media, another two hours a day. Two hours a day. And yet we're spending less time in the presence of other people. I Mean, it's, the data are just the worst you could imagine. We've got more free time, we do have more free time.

0 (27m 33s):

Wow.

1 (27m 33s):

And we've spent more than all of that free time in front of a screen.

0 (27m 38s):

Damn.

3 (27m 40s):

I feel called out.

0 (27m 41s):

Wow. Wow. Wow.

1 (27m 43s):

Well, you asked me for data.

0 (27m 44s):

No, I Mean, yeah, I'm just, I see, I see every bingeing and every TV show. I've, I see it very differently now. But that's, but

1 (27m 51s):

Of course I want people to watch this podcast. This is a

0 (27m 53s):

Different color. Yeah. But I Mean, wow.

3 (27m 56s):

Listen to the podcast on the way to meet your friends. Yes, exactly.

0 (27m 60s):

Yes. On the way to your club. That's why we love podcasts. Yeah. We're gonna continue this conversation right after this short break.

3 (28m 14s):

Robert. I I, I'm really curious about what you think, like, I'm a millennial and I have like younger cousins who are Gen Z and we spend a lot of our time on the internet. Like, I, like I met my spouse through Twitter, as crazy as that sounds. Right? So this is a world where people meet their spouses, whether it's Tinder or Instagram, and then Gen Z, they spend probably a disproportionate amount of their time online. And for some people, and I think in my generation and younger, that's where they found their connections. Would you think that's a problem? Or Do you think that can be an alternative third space that maybe can foster that sense of trust?

1 (28m 52s):

Christiana, every, you asked lots of really good questions and they're all complicated. And I'm gonna, I'm

gonna

3 (28m 57s):

Try, I'm a complicated person, Robert.

1 (28m 60s):

I'm sorry. I'm Did you say Robert? No, it's Bob, please. Oh,

0 (29m 3s):

We get Bob now. We get Bob. Okay. Wow. Okay.

3 (29m 6s):

I was gonna say Professor Putnam.

1 (29m 7s):

Oh, please. I Mean, if I get a call, a phone call and the person says, Robert, I just hang up right away because

0 (29m 16s):

If they,

1 (29m 16s):

If they know me, it's a nice screener I use as answering the phone. Okay.

3 (29m 20s):

Bob. Bob.

1 (29m 21s):

Okay. I wanna say a couple of things about social media and virtual connections and then, and how they compare to real face-to-face connections. What in one, once some people call IRL in real life, When social media first came out, everybody thought it was, You Know, unbelievably great. World peace was gonna break out. We would all have, and, and we would all be friends with each other. 'cause we'd all were connecting across that always at that time seemed a little strange to me. But the academic work, although that's true, was always more skeptical than the people who were making money by getting us onto their websites.

1 (30m 6s):

Yeah, of course. But the real question at that point, if I can put it this way, was, is Facebook better or worse than bowling leagues? I'm using that as a syn. I Mean, just as labels for those two things. And for a long

time, the academics said, I don't know, there's some ways in which Facebook is not as good as bowling leagues, but a, You Know, you'll, you guess what Mike, mark Zuckerberg thought. And then he at one point said, well, okay, maybe Putnam is right, but we're gonna create a new kind of Facebook that's gonna be even super Dan Dandy and it's gonna be wonderful, even better than bowling leagues. But the academic research, I repeat was always skeptical about that. But then came a terrible natural experiment.

1 (30m 48s):

Covid. But now I, I promise you I was gonna get more complicated, but I can tell it Christiana's easy likes to deal with complications. So I'm gonna, I have so far been phrasing this problem as if the choice we had was between either face-to-face or social media. Right? Yes. Yeah. But actually that's not true. Almost all of our networks today are simultaneously face-to-face and internet-based. Yeah. My wife, Rosemary and I do see each other a lot every day. That is, there is a face-to-face relationship there, but she has a different office than mine.

1 (31m 29s):

And astonishingly much of the time I sent her an email or send her a text and she responds. It's not, we have one set of relationships that are face to face and a different set of relationships that are internet based. They're the same. And I want to use a metaphor here if I, if I can, in chemistry, we have the idea of a, an alloy is a mixture of two different base chemicals like tin and copper, and you stirred and heated and so on. And you get something that is neither tin nor copper, but I never can remember bronze or brass or something like that. Right. And, and brass is different from either of the, either of the tin or the copper.

1 (32m 13s):

Okay. So, so far so good. Yeah. Now what I'm saying is all of our networks today are alloys. So the question really is how can we get an alloy that is, has the benefits of both. Yeah. That is to say, could we find a way to create a network that has the advantages that the internet has of not depending upon space, but that has the advantages of face-to-face ness. Namely, you can actually get together and cooperate with somebody. Do we know how to do that? And the answer is, we sure do. Okay. We know how to, For example, there are, there are networks that are, that are internet based for neighborhoods, and it's easy to contact the other people.

1 (32m 55s):

Just whenever you get the idea, you wanna borrow a rake or something, you just send out an email. But then they're also in the neighborhood. So I could go and get the, you

0 (33m 3s):

Go get the rake in person. Right?

1 (33m 5s):

So it's not a technical problem. So why don't we have lots of these things? It sounds like it'd be wonderful to have this. Right. And it turns out the real answer is these big companies, they know how to do it. They know, and I know this 'cause I've talked personally, they invited me Bob Putnam out to wherever it was in, in, in Silicon Valley to talk about social capital. Amazing. And when we had a wonderful conversation, they clearly knew what I meant. And they knew the difference between face-to-face and connected. And they knew how to use, they convey, conveyed the idea that they knew how to

0 (33m 38s):

Oh, they knew how to use their tools to get people to connect in person.

1 (33m 42s):

Yes. But how did, why don't they do that answer when it's much better for their business line if people fight than if they cooperate. Yeah.

0 (33m 49s):

And you can't sell ads in person. That's another problem. No, it's true though. You can't, you can't, you can't, you can't monetize people's connections when they aren't digital. Yeah. And so now you're limiting your revenue. You know, this seems like a, a similar problem that exists in many different industries and fields. Right. In that like, let's say food, there's nothing wrong with drinking a glass of coke. There really isn't. There's nothing wrong with having a burger from McDonald's or whatever. There really isn't. However, those products are oftentimes made to make you crave them and want them way more than you naturally would. Yeah. Right. And You Know this because you as a person, just think about you as a person.

0 (34m 32s):

You do not say to yourself, Hmm, I should do that again. You don't, you go like, ah, I can't believe I did that again. I had too much of it. But then you want more of it, and then you want more of it, and then you want more of it. Right. And we're supposed to be having, quote unquote, a balanced diet. So it's like, have your vegetables, have the salad, have the stew have the this, have the that. Yeah. And then have your snacks and you'll be fine. But it feels like we're in like an arms race against companies who go, we are not gonna give you a break. If you have a choice of 10 meals, we want you to pick the snacks 10 times and we are gonna design it in such a way that you're gonna pick the snacks 10 times. But then on the outside they'll say, no, no, no, no, no. We want you to eat healthy. And you're like, yes, but you, you made your product so that I can't Do you, do you get what I'm saying?

0 (35m 13s):

Yeah, yeah. Of course. And I think the same thing goes for like what you're saying now about social capital is they'll say it, we want to connect people, but they don't, You Know how, You Know, they don't want you to stop using the product. The simplest answer is infinite scroll. Yeah. Right. If social media companies wanted us to not endlessly use their product Sure. 'cause they'll even have a label that's like, Hey, remember to take



a break now and then, yo, you can just make me take a break. Yeah. You could literally, they could literally just go like TikTok, scroll, scroll, scroll, scroll, scroll, scroll, ba, you're done. This is your limit for the day. Yeah. And You Know what, I almost think that people would actually like the product more because people would go, oh yeah, I finished my TikTok for today, I'm done. Yeah. Do

3 (35m 52s):

You, You

0 (35m 52s):

Know what, like you are chronically online. Let's

3 (35m 54s):

Not talk about me. No, we must

0 (35m 55s):

Talk about

3 (35m 55s):

You. No, no. I'm, I'm an addict. But Bob, it's so funny you mentioned the neighborhood group and the rake. So recently I joined my neighborhood WhatsApp group and it's very nimby. I thought it was very NIMBY ish, but there was just like legit concerns about Yeah. Crime in the neighborhood and the LAPD getting out when they would come out and You Know, sometimes people would be like, there's someone walking in the neighborhood, this is their description, they're a bit suspicious. And right. There was one day it got a bit loaded 'cause it was just like, there's a black guy, he's in a hoodie or some, something like that. Yeah, yeah. You Know, very fit the description. And it was somebody else in the group who's white said, Hey, let's be careful we're not profile like it. Look, it was so refreshing for me.

3 (36m 36s):

No. Because I live in a majority white neighborhood. And I'm like, I don't wanna be the black person in the group being like, you shouldn't say that. And it's a white guy said, Hey guys, we should be careful. And people figured it out amongst themselves. Yeah. Because it's also the same neighborhood group that when there is something suspicious happening, when there is a break in and I lap D don't get there. Yeah, yeah, yeah. There's the same people in the group that may say something offhand about a description that will show up to your house and make sure you're okay. And there's been, and there's something about that group that's completely transformed. Like, I would be sensitive typically if I read about a description. Yeah. Yeah. But there, everyone's has this trust among each other to say, even If we say the wrong thing, we don't mean it in the wrong way.

3 (37m 17s):

We wanna keep our neighborhood safe. And fundamentally we all trust each other and look out for each other. And sometimes it's like, I, I need flower. Does anyone have flower? You Know, and I, this is something I've never been exposed to, but it's happening through WhatsApp. But I'd say the critical thing is we have a great leader. I don't wanna say her name 'cause she probably doesn't want people to,

0 (37m 33s):

But, but then Do you meet in person to what Rob

3 (37m 34s):

Was saying, she, she messaged me and she said, I, she was like, she told me her history and she was like, I wanna meet your husband and your kids. Right. So we're trying to figure it out. And she's the person that goes around. So

0 (37m 42s):

You see that's

3 (37m 42s):

Probably what it's, she organizes neighborhood walks. Oh, there you is. Completely changed how I perceive not just people in my neighborhood, but how I even see how others see. Oh, see profiling. Yeah. Sounds, but it's the, it's the, it's the neighborhood. There's something to the neighborhood group is what I'm trying to say, Bob.

1 (37m 57s):

Yeah. And there's wonderful data on that. If you were worried about crime in your neighborhood and you had one of two strategies you could buy, have a lot more cops on the beat, pay cops more, and You Know, arm them and so on. Or you could know one another's first name. The second is the more important crime fighting strategy that is, it's more effective to have eyes on the street from your neighbors, just as you're saying. And what I'm talking about is big, huge studies that have done this experimentally, this is taken different neighborhoods and they, this

0 (38m 28s):

Is not like an opinion, this is data that's been,

1 (38m 30s):

Yeah. Well, I'm sorry. That's what I do for a living.

0 (38m 32s):

No, I mean, that, that's what I'm, I'm clarifying for people. I love that. Yeah.

1 (38m 35s):

Well, anyway, the one, I don't want to interrupt this conversation except that I hope we have a chance to go back to bowling alone and explain and say why it explains Trump.

0 (38m 47s):

Let's fast forward to that point. We are now living in a country, and the world is living in the shadow of this country that is experiencing levels of polarization and levels of vitriol that most people say they've never experienced. Right. Right. And one of the key tenets of this moment is that people do not trust the government. They don't believe in the government. They don't believe that anything can get done. They don't believe anything will get done. And yeah. And a lot of people who are being elected into government, ironically, by the way, I always think that's ironic, is that those people are being elected into government because they say government shouldn't be a thing and we should just dismantle it all. Yeah. And fundamentally they're saying like, Hey everyone, you just take care of yourself.

0 (39m 28s):

Why does the government do your education? You do your education. And why does the government do your healthcare? You do your healthcare, you do your own research, you do your own thing. So actually help us understand, how do we go from a world where people spend less time? And, and I it is crucial to remind everyone. Bowling is is one of the things. It doesn't matter what it is. It could be a book club, it could be running group, a running group, it could be a bike club, it could anything. Yeah. Yeah. How, how does America go from having fewer clubs to creating the movement that leads to Donald Trump?

1 (39m 59s):

Right. Remember Bowling Alone said 25 years ago that we were, had been for 25 by at that point had been, it'd been 25 years we've been going downhill in terms of our social connections. Yeah, yeah. The

0 (40m 11s):

Various stories, anything that brought people together from different walks of life to connect across different boundaries.

1 (40m 17s):

That's right. And they'd been, that had been happening for 25 years. Now, 25 years later, we've gone back and done the same study. And it turns out nothing has changed. It's still going downhill. Despite all of my pleading and talking with people is going downhill, which now means for 50 years we've been going downhill. Donald Trump did not cause that. And this is the main thing I wanna say here. Donald Trump is not the cause of our problems. He's the symptom of our problems. American democracy had these problems long before Trump appeared on the scene. And most importantly, we will have those same problems leading to faltering democracy when he is no longer on the scene.

1 (40m 57s):

Hmm. Donald Trump exploited this and I mean that. So this is Bob Putnam saying, You know, Donald Trump exploited what I had discovered. That's not just me, Steve Bannon has said, I could show you the quote. Well, we were trying to figure out how we could get Donald Trump elected. And then we read this book by this crazy guy Putnam about bowling alone.

0 (41m 15s):

Wait no ways. Are you being serious?

1 (41m 16s):

Yeah, yeah. He's quote, you can find, I mean, later on. Wait, wait.

0 (41m 19s):

So how and what did they use? I don't understand. What did they use from your book to help Trump get elected? What did they identify?

1 (41m 27s):

They said effectively, as I said in the book, but I wasn't doing it. You have all these isolated people. They're, they're ripe for having a kind of populist come to power and say, you're all unhappy and isolated. Trust me, I'm the one. Does that sound familiar? Does that sound like he's the guy? Yeah, yeah, yeah. Well, that's what Bowling Alone said. And I didn't act on it. Maybe I should have, maybe I could have been. Yeah,

0 (41m 52s):

You could've been The president could've been president. I could've been President Bob, president Bob Putnam.

1 (41m 57s):

And JD Vance has said something very similar to this. There's lots of empirical evidence. I won't bore you with all the data. There's lots of data that's saying a, the strongest predictor actually of support for Donald Trump of places to support Donald Trump and people that support Donald Trump is social isolation. Now we're not just talking hypothetically, oh, it'd be nice to have more people joining clubs. We're saying the pickle that we're in as a country is precisely due to the fact that we're no longer

0 (42m 26s):

Socially isolated. Yeah. Yeah.

1 (42m 27s):

I'm not trying to say we ought to reconstruct bullying leaves, but it's gotta be something that brings us face to face. Is that making sense, Trevor? I Mean,

0 (42m 34s):

Agree. No, you, You Know, You Know why it makes complete sense is because I, I think of it through a few lenses, like you and I have talked about this a bunch. I go, one of the things I'm saddest about in America and I see around the world is the decline of churches.

1 (42m 46s):

Yes.

0 (42m 46s):

Because I go, I understand that religion has many issues that it's come with, whether it's pastors, whether it's, You Know, the way they treat certain people, whatever it might be. Right. But may you take for granted what that building did. Yes. There are very few places in our societies where you can come and regardless of the language you speak, the color of your skin, your socioeconomic background, your location, whatever it is, you are allowed to join and identify as being part of that group. And I've always thought that's maybe the most important thing is the fact that you can become a part of it. Do you, do you get what I'm saying? That's like really, really important to me. And I, I think about it through that and it's, I go like, wow, man, I understand that. People go like, oh yeah, religion, I don't care about it.

0 (43m 28s):

And I'm like, yes, but you are also losing the church. And the church was the place where you saw people to tell them you were sick. The church was the place where you got a little help. The church was the place where you got a, you found out about a new job listing. You Know, someone, well, music lesson, people learn instruments, people learn music, You Know? Yeah. People think about how all the greatest singers Yeah. Of like, You Know, the last whatever many decades came through church have all come from church. Yeah. You Know? Yeah. So the training, the connections, the, the understanding that it came from, and it's funny that you say that. When we were still on the Daily Show, I remember the, the thing I used to talk to everyone about was how Jordan Klepper would say this. I'll say to him, he'd go to all these Trump rallies and I said, Jordan, what Do you like, what Do you notice when you're at the Trump rallies?

0 (44m 9s):

What Do you notice that we don't from far? And he said something really fascinating to me once, he said, A lot of people are there for the vibes. Yes. He said, A lot of people are there for the vibes. And you think about it, Donald Trump created many clubs where clubs didn't exist. Yeah. He said, I'm coming to your town. I'm gonna sell you hats that you can all wear. We're gonna sell you little scarves that you can all wear and you're gonna come into a room and then You Know what, we're all gonna hang out and chant this. You Know, when I knew that Trump, by the way, Bob had reached the pinnacle of understanding. This is when he was at a political rally. Right. People are there ostensibly to hear about your plan for the future of the country and how you plan to run the economy.

0 (44m 51s):

And Trump was just like, let's just dance. Do you remember that moment? He's said a lot.

3 (44m 56s):

I don't remember that particular one. You don't

0 (44m 58s):

Remember that moment? Yeah.

1 (44m 58s):

Yeah. Sure. I do. I don,

0 (44m 60s):

This was one of, I I remember watching that moment going, this man is either he's completely lost it. Yes. Or he has a savant who's completely understood it. Yeah. And now I think he's the latter. Yeah. Yeah. Donald Trump.

1 (45m 11s):

I thought he was a former.

0 (45m 12s):

Yeah. Donald Trump realized in that moment. He's like, man, you guys don't, you're not here because of like, what I'm gonna do with the economy or not do with the, you just came here to hang out and we are in a club and everyone in that club says the same thing. We've been forgotten. So there's a man who grew up in a town where the factory was shut down and, and that was a piece of his club. So he's forgotten. Yes. There's somebody else who grew up in another city and because that city has lost its population, the church died and now they don't have a church. So they've been forgotten. That's right. Yeah. That's right. And someone's kids left to go to a big city. So now they don't have the, they've been forgotten. Yeah. And it's just a bunch of forgotten people who are now seen, they come together and you go, when you go home, watch the video. I promise you it is one of the most amazing things.

0 (45m 53s):

Trump literally just goes like, yo, just play my playlist. He shouted to some person who rolls with him and they just play all of his favorite. And I'm talking everything from YMCA Yeah. To Ave Maria. Like it's the most eclectic mix of music. And he just dances, Don't go anywhere. 'cause we got more What Now after this?

3 (46m 18s):

So Trevor, my question is this, like you've hit on something with this Trump thing. How do we guarantee in

this crazy world we live in that people don't start clubs of hate? Which I think what trumpet as much? Oh, that's

0 (46m 30s):

A good question

3 (46m 31s):

Actually. You Know what I Mean? It's just like, 'cause that, that's then my concern, right. Because

0 (46m 34s):

The, the Ku Klux Klan is definitely a club. Its it's a local bond. It's a local, local C club

3 (46m 38s):

Membership. Yeah. They took care of each other. Yeah.

0 (46m 39s):

You've got uniforms. Yeah.

3 (46m 40s):

It's just like, how do we, in this like very polarized moment where there is, where all sides seem to have deep resentment for each other. How do we make sure these clubs don't become spaces?

0 (46m 50s):

Or, or is that even necessary?

1 (46m 52s):

Well, yes, I think it is necessary. There are different kinds of social capital, different kinds of networks. And one dis important distinction is between what I call bridging social capital. That is ties that link you to people unlike yourself. And bonding social capital, bonding social capital are the ties that link you to people just like yourself. Oh. So my, so my bonding social capital are my friends with other elderly white male Jewish professors. That's

0 (47m 26s):

My, that's,

1 (47m 27s):

That's my bonding social capital. And my bridging social capital are my ties to people of a d generation. I have a little bit of bridging that I rely on heavily across generations. 'cause I've got my grandchildren, and I'm not saying this is important, bridging good bonding bad. Because If you get sick, the people who bring you

chicken soup are likely to affect your bonding social capital. That's a little bit what Christiana was earlier saying. The people who would really take care of her, if she got, who would bring her chicken soup or the equivalent would be bonding social capital. I'm, I'm saying bonding social capital is not necessarily bad, but bridging social capital is crucial for a modern diverse society like ours bridging across racial, across age, across gender, or across party and so on.

1 (48m 14s):

So far so good. Right,

0 (48m 16s):

Right, right. But

1 (48m 17s):

Bridging is harder to build in bonding social capital. My grandmother knew that. My grandmother said to me, Bobby, birds of a feather flock together.

0 (48m 26s):

Right.

1 (48m 27s):

She didn't think I'd understand. She, what she meant was, Bobby, bridging social capital is harder to build and bonding social capital. But she didn't think I'd understand that, which is why she used the avian metaphor about bird, about birds. But that's the basic point. So here's the challenge. Much of, of Trump's support, it draws from different kinds of demographic groups of course, but it's bonded heavily on politics and not bridging at all. And so now I'm back at the question, why doesn't Putnam saying he wants lots of, of, of Ku Klux Klan? Yeah. And the answer is, I don't want lots of Ku Klux Klan because it's bonding and I want a lot of more bridging.

1 (49m 7s):

Does that make sense to what I'm saying?

0 (49m 9s):

Yeah, that makes, that makes sense. And actually, and I wanna know how to do it well, but I'm actually gonna throw this before we move on. Yeah. I'm gonna throw something out here, maybe controversial. I would argue the reason the Democrats didn't do as well in this election is because they were bonding. They weren't bridging. Yes.

1 (49m 23s):

Yeah.



0 (49m 23s):

So if I look at Barack, I look at Barack Obama's, they were bonding and they thought they were bridging. Yeah. But if I look at Barack Obama's campaign, right? Barack Obama was going, Hey, hey, hey, hey, hey, I don't care if you're in Kentucky, let's connect it. Let's connect. Yeah. Do you have this issue? I have this issue. This is something I grew up with. You grew up, my grandmother looks like you, my mother looks like you. My father looked like that. My, this, I grew up in this world. He was bridging. He's going to Iowa and Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. And he was like, yes, we can. Like it was bridging, bridging, bridging,

1 (49m 48s):

Bridging, bridging. Absolutely. We, we, we, it's gotta be. Yes. Right? Yeah.

0 (49m 51s):

And so as much as it's easy for everyone to be like Donald Trump and blah, blah, You Know, and we all guilty of that. But I think of like the Democrats in this election, a lot of it was bonding stuff as well. It was very much like, You Know, like, oh, You Know, white men are this, and the, the, the rich have done that. And, and it became bonding that way as opposed to the coalition of saying like, Bernie even did well by the way, when he was running, he did a lot of bridging. Like, You Know, Hey, let's all join. We are all struggling. Let's all come together as struggling people. We all deserve healthcare. You all, doesn't matter where you're from. Bridge, bridge, bridge And I think in this election in particular, there was a lot of bonding from both parties.

0 (50m 31s):

And as crazy as this may sound to a lot of people, I think Donald Trump engaged in a little more bridging than people will give him credit for, which I think is why he connected more than people thought he would in some spaces.

3 (50m 44s):

I wanna know what Bob thinks of that.

1 (50m 46s):

So this is, sorry, I you, you didn't invite me on here to cite all my books, but I'm going to cite yet another book.

0 (50m 52s):

No, that's exactly why we invited you on here. You're expert.

1 (50m 55s):

Okay. I want to talk about the growing gap between rich folks and poor folks in America. And the book was called Our Kids. The book was focused on a whole series of charts and graphs that showed the gap

between rich kids and poor kids growing. And I'll say more about what I meant, that by that, but in particular by Rich, I didn't mean literally having lots of money. The BA book is based on the Upper Third of American Society, which is basically college educated folks.

0 (51m 24s):

Okay.

1 (51m 25s):

And, and the lower two thirds of America, which is basically people who didn't graduate from four years of college. And what that book showed is a growing gap also among their parents. Those two groups are increasingly, they don't marry one another. It used to be that there were people would marry across these class lines, but they don't Now. They used to be that they, that they would live in the same neighborhood, but they're were increasingly living in, not racially segregated, but class segregated homes. And I, and what I'm trying to say is that class lens was when I wrote the book, at least as important as the racial lens. Hmm. And it's becoming relatively speaking, the class lens is becoming more important relative to the racial lens.

1 (52m 13s):

The plight facing working class whites is the same as the plight facing working class blacks. That's what Bernie Sanders noticed. He was talking about everybody. He was down in not at the bottom, meaning the poorest of the poor, but the lower two thirds of the, of the country. Right. And I think that the Democratic Party, this may be controversial. I think the Democratic Party has gotta start focusing more on those class differences and less exclusively on the racial or other identity issues. Now it sounds like I'm saying let's forget about black folks and, and I'm not saying that, I'm saying let's really focus on working class black folks 'cause they're the ones who are falling further and further behind.

3 (52m 60s):

Yeah. To follow up on that, they, 'cause a lot has been said about black male increasing vote for Republican, they actually split the vote and they look at the black male vote specifically. And the black men most likely to joke, vote for Trump when non-college educated. Yes. And unchurched. Exactly.

1 (53m 16s):

Unchurched

3 (53m 17s):

As well. Unchurched. That was the key. They were absolutely secular up to a high school diploma. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Black young black men. That's the group most likely to vote for Trump. The black men that voted Democrat are college educated, tend to attend church professionals. Yeah. Ah, and that's where, that's good. And they, they vote at similar levels for Democrats as black women do in general. So that that group that's actually splitting off from the Democratic party is like the most oppressed class among black people.

0 (53m 46s):

I almost wanna know what you think the future will be because I, I, I remember speaking, I, I forget who this person was. It was such a wonderful conversation. We had in one of my first times going to London and I was talking to them about living in America and I was talking to them about coming from South Africa and everything. And, and this woman said to me, she said, she said, oh darling, she said, I can't wait for South Africa and and America to get over race because then they'll realize that everything's all about class, baby. It's all about class. And it, it really was an interesting idea, which has stuck with me because I go like, yeah, the most

3 (54m 19s):

Classy society ever. No.

0 (54m 21s):

Yeah. No, but no, but what I, what I liked about it was this is she forced me to hone in on something that I think people do take for granted. Yeah. Oftentimes when we talk about issues that are like pertaining to black people, you'll be like, oh, black people have a, that has just become an easy identifier for a class issue, right? Yes. Exactly. And that's why like people, like, that's why people like Dr. Martin Luther King, like MLK was like, yo, I'm fighting for class. A lot of his stuff was class related.

3 (54m 48s):

Very socialist.

0 (54m 49s):

Yeah. He was fighting for class. And black people are disproportionately affected by it. But that's why like even the Black Panther party, they found a coalition Yeah. Between white people who were proudly racist and black people who were militantly fighting against racism. But they were like, yo

3 (55m 5s):

Union jobs.

0 (55m 6s):

Yeah. The guy was like, Hey man, we should all come together because we are all being affected by this. And in all of these cases, by the way, they formed clubs, the Black Panthers formed a mini club that wasn't the Black Panthers that involved all of these poor people. Yeah. Dr. Martin Luther King. He formed multiple clubs and chapters and all of these organizations. And it's interesting to see what you're saying is like these clubs came together around the issue of class. And so now let me, let me ask you this then. So Do you think, say the people who are in the bottom two thirds

1 (55m 37s):

Yes.

0 (55m 38s):

Are they more likely to be negative effect negatively affected by not having a social club?

1 (55m 44s):

Yes. And they're certainly much more likely to be socially isolated. I Mean, ah, okay. They've got, they've got at least two strikes against them. Well, maybe three A, they're more socially isolated.

0 (55m 58s):

Okay.

1 (55m 59s):

And B, they're poorer financially. And c they have got less education. So all that, those folks are in a pickle. Hmm. And what that means is it's important to make, just understand the math. It's a simple, simple arithmetic. We could have a clean system here in which we had all the college educated people, You Know, vote for the Democrats and all the non-college educated people vote for the Republicans. What's wrong with that? Well, there are a lot more of them than of us. We the Democrats, if we're gonna retain power democratically, we've got to begin appealing, not ignoring race, I'm not saying that, but appealing more to the class-based interests.

1 (56m 43s):

I wanna try to end with three to-dos.

0 (56m 47s):

Oh yeah, that's great. 'cause that's what Christiana was asking for. What, what were you gonna ask? 'cause then you can say it and then he'll, I was asking for my homework. The to-dos. Okay, great. So the What Now? The What Now, Bob Putnam,

1 (56m 58s):

I'm gonna try to keep it simple. Not, not because you guys couldn't understand more, something more complicated, but because I think we've gotta understand in very simple terms, one go young is much more important that we focus on young people regardless of where they are right now, because they're the future. And I'm now talking as an historian, looking back, not just over the last, You Know, 5, 10, 20, 50 years. I'm looking over the last 125 years in, in my last book, which was called The Upswing. I looked over the whole of American history over the last 125 years. And big changes are not the creation of old guys like me, old guys like me sometimes. We've been around so long that we understand that it doesn't have to be the way it is today, but we're not the people who have the ideas that will work to build social capital and to save America

in the, I don't know, 2050s or something.

1 (57m 51s):

I'm gonna be long gone. So first thing is go young and inspire the young people to come up with the new bowling leagues. It's not gonna be bowling leagues, it's gonna be something else. But almost surely will involve something of, of high tech. But it, it will involve real personal relations with other

0 (58m 7s):

People before you move on. A perfect example of that for me was Pokemon Go. So I I I'm assuming neither of you played it, but I was, I was a huge Pokemon Go fan. Huge. Huge, huge. I think this was the best execution of a video game in the modern age because it was a video game that everyone played on. It was on your phones. Yeah. Right. And the goal was to catch Pokemon. You don't need to know what any of this is, just think of a game where you're trying to catch little creatures. Okay. But what they did that was amazing was you had to catch the creatures in the real world. Ah. So they used your camera on your phone and you would literally have to run out into the streets to catch these digital creatures.

0 (58m 48s):

And so at first it was just like, oh, this is silly and this is fun. But I will, I'll never forget the joy I experienced when one night I was in New York and I was running with a group of people in Central Park Strangers at 11:30 PM because someone had tweeted and told us that there was a snore la which is one of the creatures. There was a SX in Central Park. And Bob and Christiana, when I tell you there were, If I was just to estimate, there were like maybe 500 people from like, from like little kids who had dragged their parents out of the house all the way through to like adults who are playing the game running. And I remember at 1.1 of the kids turned looked at me, well 'cause we're all running 'cause there's a time limit.

0 (59m 30s):

You don't know how long the, the creature will be there for. So we're all running through Central Park together. And one of the kid turns, turns, looks at me, this kid's like maybe like 14, 15. And he looks at me and he is like, he's like Trevor Noah. He's like, you, you played Pokemon Girl. And he's like, now I know I'm in the right place and we run it together. But I what I, what I loved about it was it, to what you're saying, it was the perfect culmination. It wasn't the either or. Yeah. We were all playing all digital game. It was the alloy. You could play the game at home and we were playing it at home, but you could not help but bump into other people who were playing the game as well in the real world. And it, it was such a beautiful 'cause once the snx was gone, all everyone could do now is talk. Where are you from? Yeah. Hey, where Do you live?

0 (1h 0m 11s):

Yeah. Where did you, what's the best one you've caught? What have you. And this was like the game won awards, by the way, even for getting people fit and running and moving it. Yeah. But I I, I love that. So like when you say the going young and figuring out the, the hybrid, I think there are ways to do it. 'cause some

people would be like, oh, I don't know If you can, I think we actually have seen one of the ways, and I know because I played it, but Yes. Okay, so what's rule number two?

1 (1h 0m 32s):

Rule number two is go local. Go local. All the times that there have been major social revolutions, they bubbled up from the bottom. And at local levels, people can more easily cooperate across party and other lines because somebody's gotta fix the sewers. And so yeah. You don't have to have an ideological discussion about how important is, is the environment. You, everybody knows that the sewers gotta be fixed if we're gonna be able to survive in this town or the schools. You Know, you can have a national debate about, I don't know, some issue in education, but, but somebody's gotta fix our school's right here.

1 (1h 1m 17s):

And so sometimes left wingers are in favor of national solutions. And, and the for race, we did have to go national because there were whole regions of the country, which were, if we went local, it would, we would've stayed segregated forever. So I'm not saying always go local, but If you wanna have a major revolution, and this, this is exactly what MLK did, right? He didn't start with his march on Washington. He started in in Montgomery. What Do you think is the most important social reform in the history of America? I'm gonna tell you in just a second. The high school, when was the high school invented? The high school was invented in 1910. God did not invent the high school. It was invented.

1 (1h 1m 57s):

And where was the high school? By high school, I Mean a secondary school that, a public high school that everybody could

0 (1h 2m 2s):

Go to. Yeah. Yeah.

1 (1h 2m 3s):

We'd had private schools of course as like Eaton or whatever. But I'm talking about public high schools. First place in the world was in 1910 in flyover country in America. It was not invented in Massachusetts or in Chicago or in LA or what It was invented in small towns in the middle of America. And it went viral. And within 20 years, every city in America, every city in town in America had a high public high school. That's viral. 20 years it went from

0 (1h 2m 32s):

That's amazing. So

1 (1h 2m 33s):

What I'm trying to say is the really good ideas, policy ideas, the next time

0 (1h 2m 39s):

They spread.

1 (1h 2m 40s):

And thirdly, and I wanna come back now to this issue of religion. Go morality, stick with me. I'm an academic, but I'm about to start preaching at you. Both

4 (1h 2m 50s):

Of you.

1 (1h 2m 51s):

I I apologize for that. When we look at long run changes, long run changes in political polarization, in economic inequality, in connections, and so on. The leading indicator, it turns out that people in any given period and place actually think they have obligations to other people.

0 (1h 3m 17s):

Hmm.

1 (1h 3m 18s):

We need to have a moral reawakening in America. I'm talking about simple golden rule. Read the sermon on the mount. I Mean, any, any religion says worry at least as much about other people as you do about yourself.

0 (1h 3m 31s):

Love that

1 (1h 3m 32s):

Religion should, religion should be a we phenomenon, not an eye phenomenon. Yeah. So if I had a magic wand, I don't, but maybe somebody listens, will have a magic wand. I try to make the magic wand, make young people remember young in localities across America, think that they have obligations to other people. Is that making sense? I Mean that's yeah, that makes,

0 (1h 3m 58s):

That makes complete sense. Sounds.

1 (1h 3m 59s):

And and my basic message is if we want fix America, and I desperately wanna fix America, it's probably not gonna come in my lifetime, but I wanna have it come at least in my grandchildren's lifetime. And we gotta get

about it now. And that requires mobilizing large numbers of people at the local large numbers of young people at the local level, thinking about their obligations to other people and not just about themselves. Sorry, that's the message.

0 (1h 4m 27s):

No, no, I don't think you have to be sorry. I think it's, it's given us homework. So play Pokemon, go go young. Yes. With people in your local neighborhood. Yeah. And help them catch the Pokemon that they can't. Yes. Yeah. That's essentially because, and then 'cause you're helping each other. And then

3 (1h 4m 42s):

When you speak to them, talk to them about the spiritual awakening.

4 (1h 4m 46s):

Yeah. So

1 (1h 4m 48s):

You guys are gonna, you're gonna lead this revolution. I'm, yeah. Line me up. Let me know how I can join. Oh, we love

0 (1h 4m 54s):

It. Bob, this has been amazing. Thank you so much for taking the time. Thank you Bob. You Know, it's such a simple idea and unfortunately sometimes the best ideas are so simple that people don't want them. It's simple,

3 (1h 5m 4s):

But it's hard.

0 (1h 5m 5s):

Yeah. No, but that's what I Mean. It's like, it's the same way like eating healthy. It's a simple idea. Yeah. Eat the vegetables and don't eat things that come in packets. I Mean your body, your body changes and people are like, yeah, yeah, yeah. But I need something more complicated than that. Might not. But yeah. I wanna say thank you very much. Thank you for doing the work. Thank you for taking the time with us. And You Know, we started at Robert, we end at Bob. Thank you very much. It was wonderful getting to know you. And I hope, I hope you do get to see some of this in your lifetime. So don't, don't write it off yet. You keep talking about you're gonna be gone. Maybe some of it will change. We'll see. We'll do our best.

1 (1h 5m 38s):

Thank you Christiana. Thank you. And thank you Trevor.



0 (1h 5m 41s):

Thank you so much Bob.

2 (1h 5m 43s):

Bye.

0 (1h 5m 49s):

What Now with Trevor Noah is produced by Spotify Studios and partnership with Day Zero Productions. The show is executive produced by Trevor Noah Sonin and Jody Agan. Our senior producer is Jess Hackle. Claire Slaughter is our producer. Music mixing and mastering by Hannah Brown. Thank you so much for listening. Join me next Thursday for another episode of What Now?